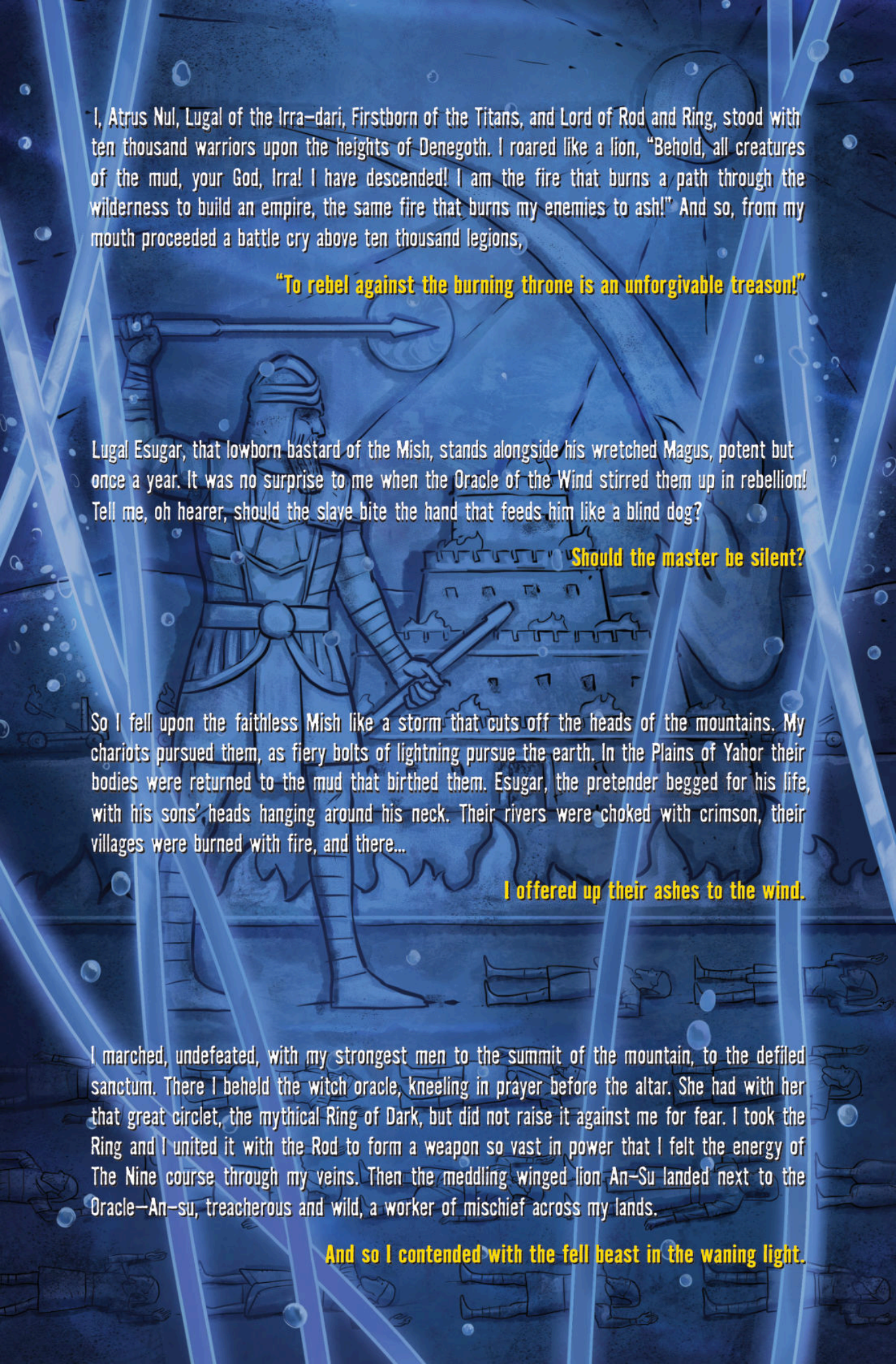


CHAPTER 3





I, Atrus Nul, Lugal of the Irra-dari, Firstborn of the Titans, and Lord of Rod and Ring, stood with ten thousand warriors upon the heights of Denegoth. I roared like a lion, "Behold, all creatures of the mud, your God, Irra! I have descended! I am the fire that burns a path through the wilderness to build an empire, the same fire that burns my enemies to ash!" And so, from my mouth proceeded a battle cry above ten thousand legions,

"To rebel against the burning throne is an unforgivable treason!"

Lugal Esugar, that lowborn bastard of the Mish, stands alongside his wretched Magus, potent but once a year. It was no surprise to me when the Oracle of the Wind stirred them up in rebellion! Tell me, oh hearer, should the slave bite the hand that feeds him like a blind dog?

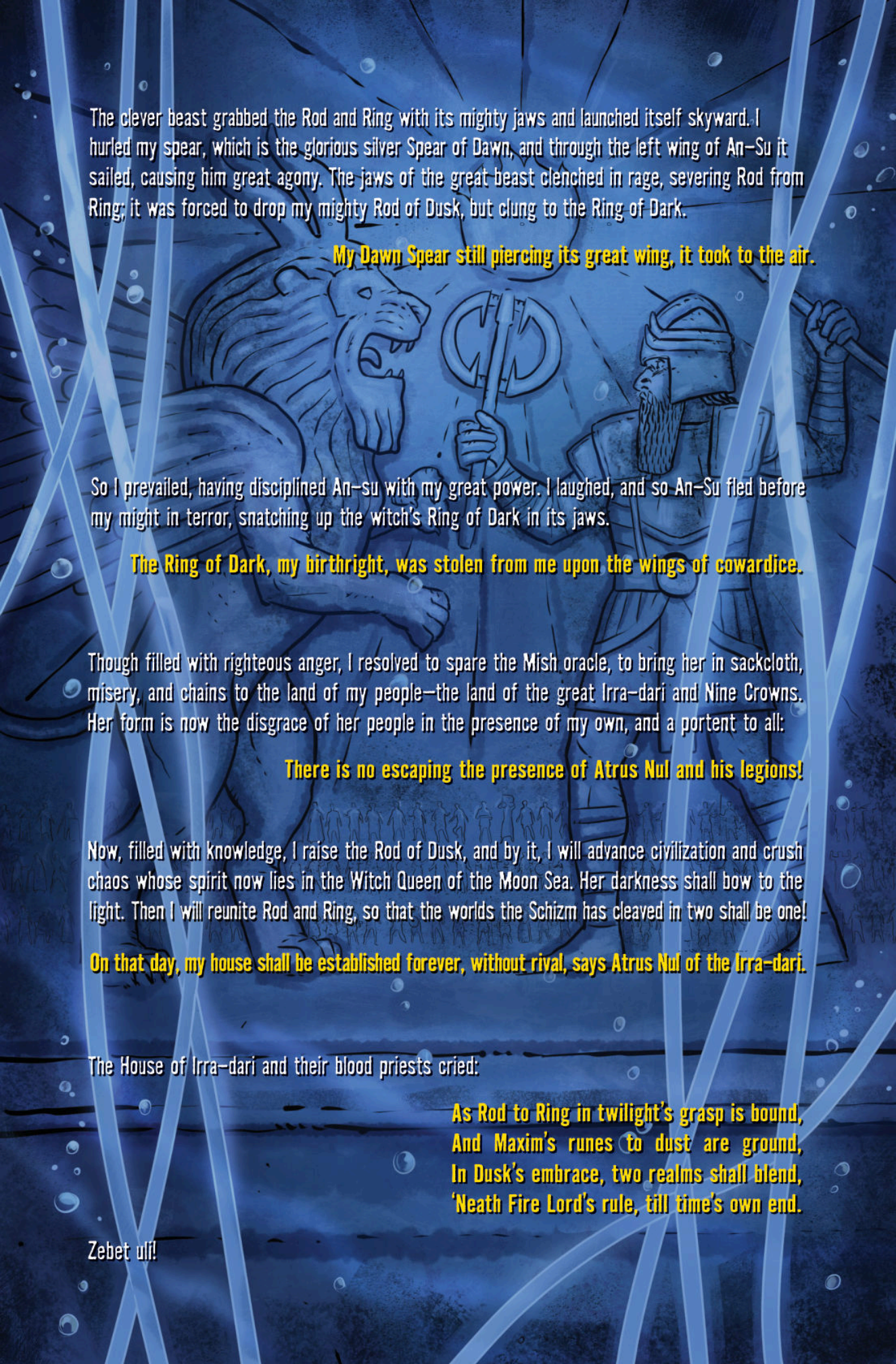
Should the master be silent?

So I fell upon the faithless Mish like a storm that cuts off the heads of the mountains. My chariots pursued them, as fiery bolts of lightning pursue the earth. In the Plains of Yahor their bodies were returned to the mud that birthed them. Esugar, the pretender begged for his life, with his sons' heads hanging around his neck. Their rivers were choked with crimson, their villages were burned with fire, and there...

I offered up their ashes to the wind.

I marched, undefeated, with my strongest men to the summit of the mountain, to the defiled sanctum. There I beheld the witch oracle, kneeling in prayer before the altar. She had with her that great circlet, the mythical Ring of Dark, but did not raise it against me for fear. I took the Ring and I united it with the Rod to form a weapon so vast in power that I felt the energy of The Nine course through my veins. Then the meddling winged lion An-Su landed next to the Oracle—An-su, treacherous and wild, a worker of mischief across my lands.

And so I contended with the fell beast in the waning light.



The clever beast grabbed the Rod and Ring with its mighty jaws and launched itself skyward. I hurled my spear, which is the glorious silver Spear of Dawn, and through the left wing of An-Su it sailed, causing him great agony. The jaws of the great beast clenched in rage, severing Rod from Ring; it was forced to drop my mighty Rod of Dusk, but clung to the Ring of Dark.

My Dawn Spear still piercing its great wing, it took to the air.

So I prevailed, having disciplined An-su with my great power. I laughed, and so An-Su fled before my might in terror, snatching up the witch's Ring of Dark in its jaws.

The Ring of Dark, my birthright, was stolen from me upon the wings of cowardice.

Though filled with righteous anger, I resolved to spare the Mish oracle, to bring her in sackcloth, misery, and chains to the land of my people—the land of the great Irra-dari and Nine Crowns. Her form is now the disgrace of her people in the presence of my own, and a portent to all:

There is no escaping the presence of Atrus Nul and his legions!

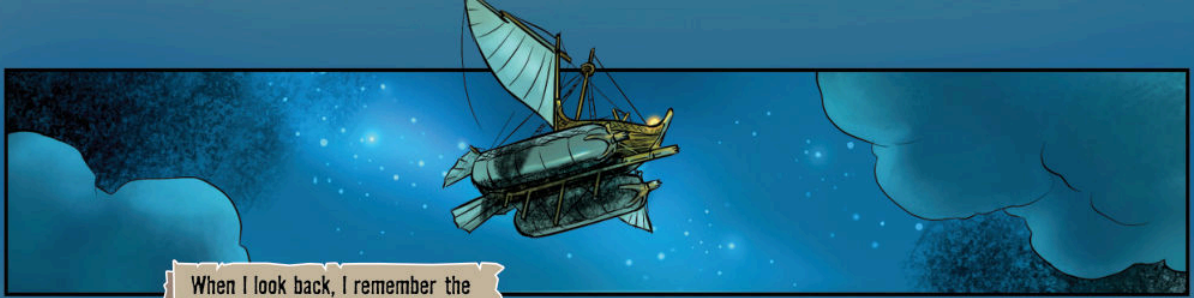
Now, filled with knowledge, I raise the Rod of Dusk, and by it, I will advance civilization and crush chaos whose spirit now lies in the Witch Queen of the Moon Sea. Her darkness shall bow to the light. Then I will reunite Rod and Ring, so that the worlds the Schizm has cleaved in two shall be one!

On that day, my house shall be established forever, without rival, says Atrus Nul of the Irra-dari.

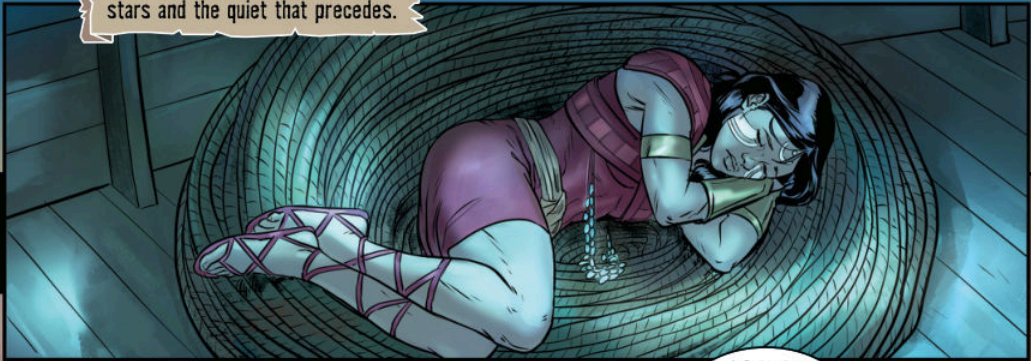
The House of Irra-dari and their blood priests cried:

**As Rod to Ring in twilight's grasp is bound,
And Maxim's runes to dust are ground,
In Dusk's embrace, two realms shall blend,
'Neath Fire Lord's rule, till time's own end.**

Zebet ulf!



When I look back, I remember the stars and the quiet that precedes.



MOTHER, ARE YOU READY? IT'S TIME.

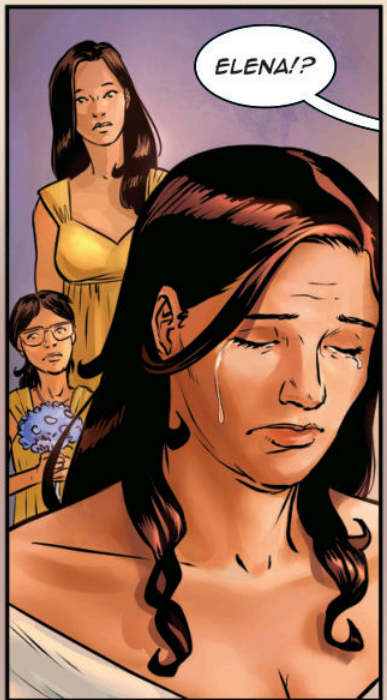


LOOK AT HOW PRETTY GRANDMA BELLA LOOKS IN HER WEDDING DRESS, ELENA.



LET ME SEE YOU! WELL, THAT NECKLACE LOOKS SO NICE, ELENA. YOU'RE GOING TO BE OUR FLOWER GIRL TODAY. CAN YOU DO THAT FOR GRANDMA?

OK, GRANDMA BELLA. BUT — BUT WHY ARE YOU CRYING?



ELENA!?



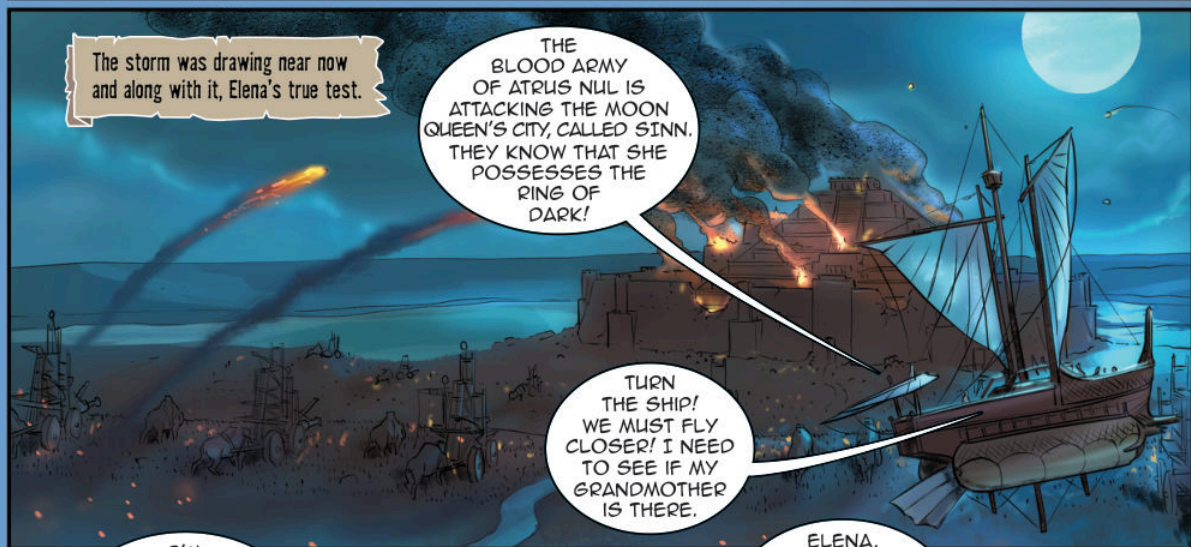
ELENA!?
TIME TO WAKE
UP!

WHA—
WHAT'S HAPPEN-
ING?



IT'S
WORSE THAN
WE PREDICTED,
ELENA. ATRUS NUL
HAS BROUGHT AN
ENORMOUS
ARMY.

OH
NO! — THIS
IS REAL ISN'T
IT?



The storm was drawing near now
and along with it, Elena's true test.

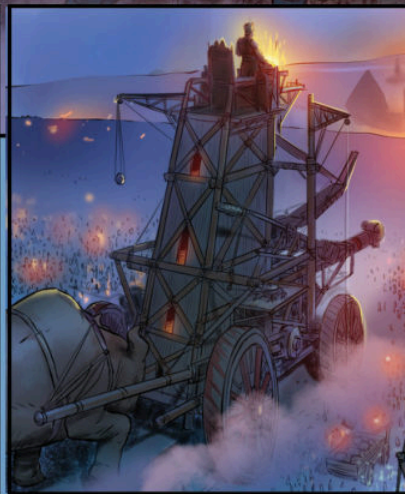
THE
BLOOD ARMY
OF ATRUS NUL IS
ATTACKING THE MOON
QUEEN'S CITY, CALLED SINN.
THEY KNOW THAT SHE
POSSESSES THE
RING OF
DARK!

TURN
THE SHIP!
WE MUST FLY
CLOSER! I NEED
TO SEE IF MY
GRANDMOTHER
IS THERE.



I'M
AFRAID SINN
WILL SOON FALL.
ITS WALLS ARE NO
MATCH FOR THESE
CATAPULTS!

ELENA,
TAKE THIS.
YOU AND THE
OTHERS MAY NEED
THIS ARMOR
SOON!





THAT
SHIP— IT'S
GOING TO
CRASH!

OH
NO! BUT
LOOK THERE!
DOMINION FORCES
HAVE BREACHED
THE OUTER
WALL!



THE
WAR MACHINE
OF ATRUS
NUL!
IS
THAT
HIM!?
THAT'S
HIM



BRACE
YOUR-
SELVES!
WE ARE
GOING TO CRASH
INTO ENEMY LINES!
WE MUST TRY AND
STEER OURSELVES
AWAY FROM
THEM.

UH!
WASN'T
THAT OUR
PILOT!?

I'LL
HOLD
THE SAILS
MYSELF!



IF I CAN
JUST HIT THAT
WOOD BEAM,
MAYBE—



GOOD
THINKING,
ELENA! SECOND
HARPOON
AWAY!

GOOD
SHOT!
THE SHIP IS
SLOWING!



REPEL THEM! FIGHT FOR YOUR CITY! FIGHT FOR YOUR QUEEN!

GRAND-MOTHER? COULD IT BE?



WHO?

NEVER-MIND SHE IS TOO YOUNG— I THOUGHT—



WATCH OUT! INCOMING!



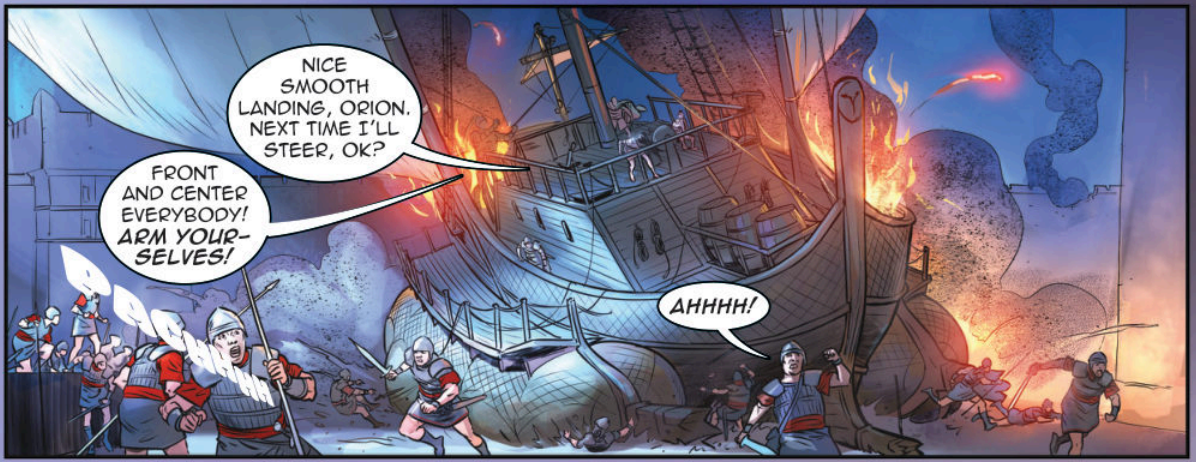
KA BOOM!

AHH!

HOLD ON!



WE ARE GOING DOWN!



NICE
SMOOTH
LANDING, ORION.
NEXT TIME I'LL
STEER, OK?

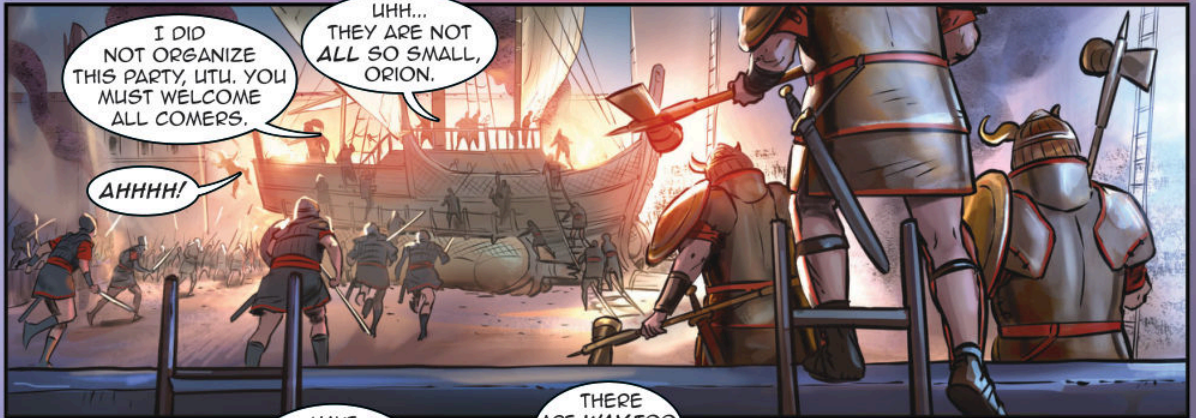
FRONT
AND CENTER
EVERYBODY!
ARM YOUR-
SELVES!

AHHHH!



AT LEAST
THEY ARE SMALL
ONES. *COME!*
MEET YOUR
DEATHS!

LOOKS
LIKE WE HAVE
A WELCOMING
PARTY!



I DID
NOT ORGANIZE
THIS PARTY, LUTU. YOU
MUST WELCOME
ALL COMERS.

UHH...
THEY ARE NOT
ALL SO SMALL,
ORION.

AHHHH!



HAVE
I MENTIONED
I'VE NEVER
USED ONE OF
THESE?

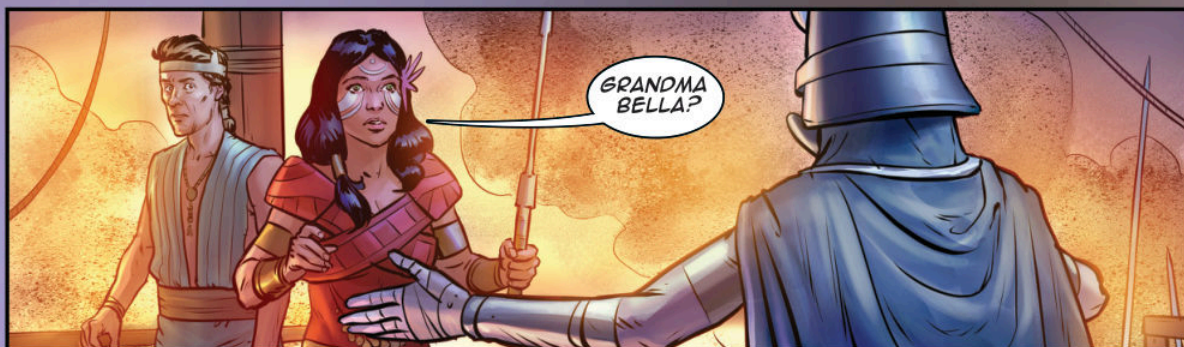
THERE
ARE WAY TOO
MANY OF
THEM...

HERE
THEY
COME!

JUST
SWING THE
SHARP SIDE,
MAGUS!
ORION, BEHIND
YOU!



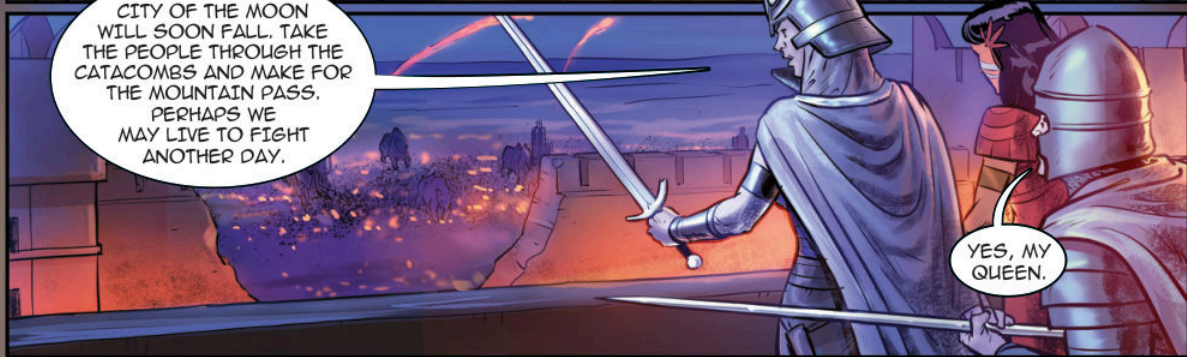






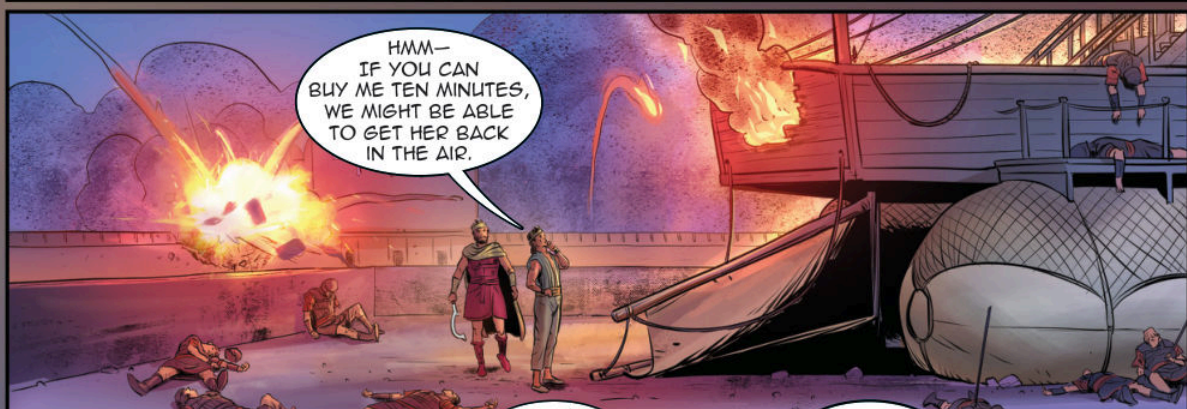
GET THEM, LADS!

ROUND THEM UP! TAKE THIS SCUM TO THE MINES!



THE CITY OF THE MOON WILL SOON FALL. TAKE THE PEOPLE THROUGH THE CATACOMBS AND MAKE FOR THE MOUNTAIN PASS. PERHAPS WE MAY LIVE TO FIGHT ANOTHER DAY.

YES, MY QUEEN.



HMM— IF YOU CAN BUY ME TEN MINUTES, WE MIGHT BE ABLE TO GET HER BACK IN THE AIR.



MAKE IT FIVE, WE'VE GOT TROUBLE

IRRA'S BEARD, I'LL DO THE BEST I CAN.



THIS TIME, WE ARE THE WELCOMING PARTY!



ELENA! WATCH THE WALL!

THWOOSH

TRYING....!

MELCHIOR! NOW WOULD BE A GOOD TIME!





WE HAVE
LOST THE CITY,
BUT HE LEAVES
WITHOUT THE RING
HE CAME
FOR.

THAT'S...
THAT'S HIM... UH...
I SEE HIM! IN MY
HEAD! I CAN
SEE—



GOOD...
FOCUS, ELENA.
WHAT DO YOU
SEE? HIM!
ELENA!

ELENA!!
AVOID HIS
GAZE!

SO MUCH
DESTRUCTION!
SO MUCH
DEATH!

I'M OK.
BUT I CAN HEAR
IT AGAIN. THAT HORRIBLE
SOUND THAT FIRST
BROUGHT ME TO THE
HOLLOWLANDS. UHH!
I FEEL—







LOOK—
SOME OLD
RUINS BELOW!
WHAT IS THIS
PLACE?

THIS IS
THE FORTRESS OF
INDRAS NA. BEYOND, YOU
CAN SEE THE DESTROYED
MOON BRIDGE THAT LEADS
TO THE DARK LANDS
OF KUR.

We arrived at the old gateway to the
underworld of Kur, now ruined, but
still beckoning to the dead.



GRANDMA
BELLA, WE
SHOULDN'T BE HERE.
WE NEED TO GO
HOME.

ELENA,
IF WE DON'T
STOP THE SON OF
WAR, ATRUS NUL, THERE
WILL BE NO HOME
TO GO BACK
TO.



HELP ME
UNDERSTAND.
WHAT ARE YOU DOING
HERE? WHY WON'T
YOU COME BACK
TO US?

MY BODY
IS FADING THERE.
I'M MUCH STRONGER
HERE. I HAVE TO STOP
ATRUS NUL— SOON
YOU'LL KNOW
WHY.



YOU FIGHT
WELL, ELENA. I
ONCE WIELDED
THE WEAPON
YOU DO.

WHY
DID YOU
GIVE IT UP
TO ME?

IT
PROVED
TOO MUCH.
ITS WEIGHT
PAINED ME.



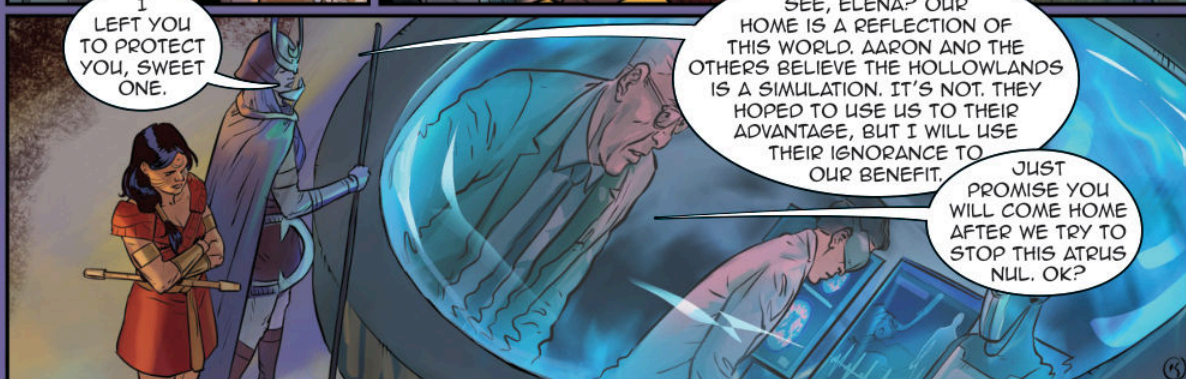
GRANDMA,
IS THERE NO OTHER
WAY? CAN WE GO BACK
HOME AND RETURN
WITH HELP?



NO, MY
CHILD. THEY
WON'T BELIEVE
US. THEY DON'T
BELIEVE THIS
PLACE IS
REAL.

HMM...
ANOTHER
POOL?

WHY DID
YOU LEAVE US
FOR THIS PLACE
WHICH PROBABLY
ISN'T EVEN
REAL?



I
LEFT YOU
TO PROTECT
YOU, SWEET
ONE.

DON'T YOU
SEE, ELENA? OUR
HOME IS A REFLECTION OF
THIS WORLD. AARON AND THE
OTHERS BELIEVE THE HOLLOWLANDS
IS A SIMULATION. IT'S NOT. THEY
HOPED TO USE US TO THEIR
ADVANTAGE, BUT I WILL USE
THEIR IGNORANCE TO
OUR BENEFIT.

JUST
PROMISE YOU
WILL COME HOME
AFTER WE TRY TO
STOP THIS ATRUS
NUL. OK?



OK—
SOUNDS
TERRIFYING BUT
I'M READY TO
LEARN.

I WILL,
SWEET ONE—
NOW LET ME TEACH
YOU HOW TO USE THAT
WEAPON TO *YOUR*
ADVANTAGE.

THE DAWN
SPEAR— IT'S MORE THAN
IT SEEMS. ISIN ADA DIDN'T
TEACH YOU THIS? I SEE THAT
I MUST TRAIN YOU FOR WHAT
IS TO COME. THERE IS
MUCH YOU DON'T
KNOW.

ISIN
ADA HAS FORESEEN THAT
IF ATRUS NUL JOINS ROD AND
RING, HE WILL TRY TO PIERCE THE VEIL
— OUR WORLDS WILL BECOME ONE.
MACHINES WILL BECOME LIFELESS
STATUES AS THE LUGAL'S MAGICIANS
WREST CONTROL OF THEIR ELECTRICAL
IMPULSES; ENTIRE ARMIES WILL STAND
CONFOUNDED BY WORDS OF POWER
ECHOING IN THEIR
MINDS....

WORDS
OF POWER?
UH... OK.

THE PEOPLE
OF EARTH WILL COWER
BEFORE UNDEAD ARMIES RAISED
UP BY NECROMANCERS. YOU MUST
UNDERSTAND, ELENA. PEOPLE ARE
DESTROYED BY WHAT THEY DO NOT
UNDERSTAND. IN THAT DAY, IF ATRUS
NUL HAS HIS WAY... BOTH OUR
WORLD AND THEIRS WILL BE
CONTAMINATED BY FORBIDDEN
KNOWLEDGE.

OK, I
THINK I GET IT
NOW— AND *THAT'S*
WHY YOU WANTED
ME TO FIND YOU
HERE?

I CAN'T DO
THIS ALONE. I NEED YOU,
ELENA, TO BRING BALANCE
BACK. OUR WORLD CAN NEVER
KNOW ABOUT THIS PLACE,
OR THE MAGIC IT HOLDS.
WILL YOU LEARN
FROM ME?

BRAVERY
DOESN'T COME
NATURALLY BUT I
WILL TRY,
GRANDMA





COMMANDER, ORGANIZE AID FOR THE WOUNDED. SEE TO IT THAT EVERYONE HAS FOOD AND A PLACE TO SHELTER.

RIGHT AWAY, MY QUEEN!



ORION, WE SHOULD BE CAREFUL. ELENA'S SPEAR AND SABELLA'S RING TOGETHER COULD PROVE DANGEROUS.

GOOD!... WE NEED MORE DANGEROUS ON OUR SIDE.



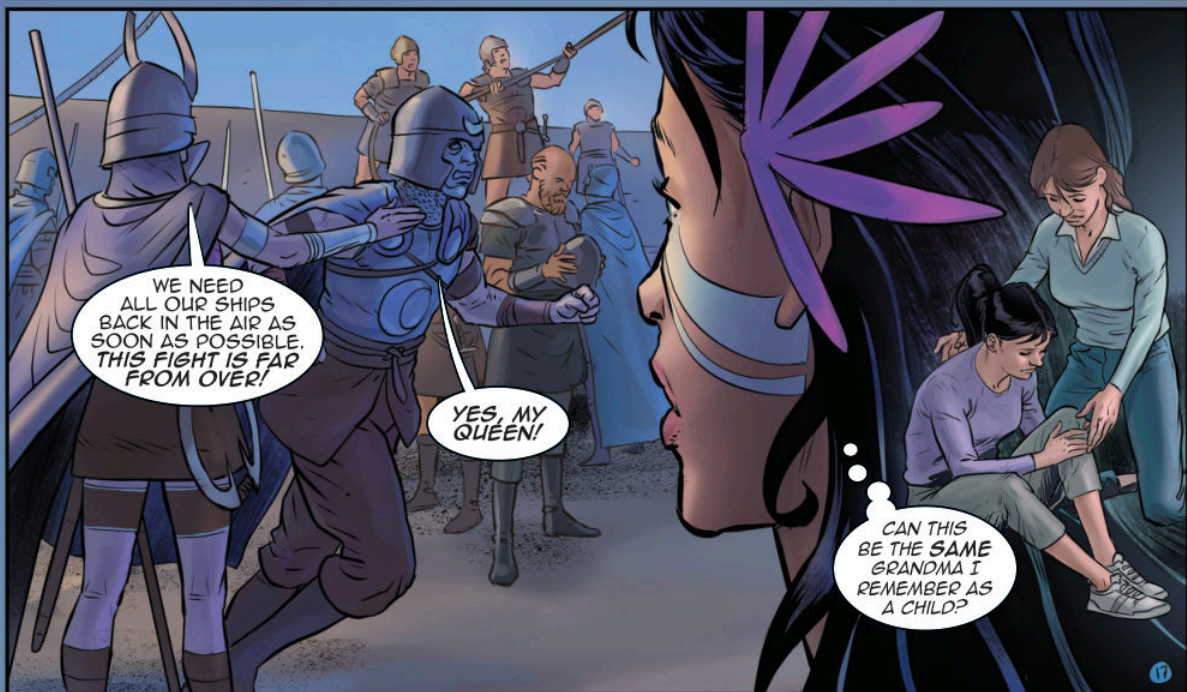
YOU KNOW THE ORACLE'S PROPHECY LIKE I DO. IF THESE FALL INTO THE WRONG HANDS— IT'S OVER.

LISTEN, SHORT LEGS. WHY DO YOU COWER BEHIND SUPER-STITION?



I'M JUST SAYIN'... HOW CAN I SIN ADA TRUST QUEEN SABELLA AFTER WHAT SHE DID TO US?

UGH... AGAIN WITH THAT FEELING... WHAT IS UTU HIDING?



WE NEED ALL OUR SHIPS BACK IN THE AIR AS SOON AS POSSIBLE. THIS FIGHT IS FAR FROM OVER!

YES, MY QUEEN!

CAN THIS BE THE SAME GRANDMA I REMEMBER AS A CHILD?



I HEARD THERE WAS A LOST LIBRARY HERE. I'D LOVE TO SEE IF THAT'S TRUE.

I'LL GO WITH YOU, MELCHIOR— ANY CHANCE WE WILL FIND WEAPONS THERE?

IT'S A LIBRARY.

YES? YOU JUST SAID THAT.



UTU?



HELLO?



UGH! MY HEAD— IT HURTS!

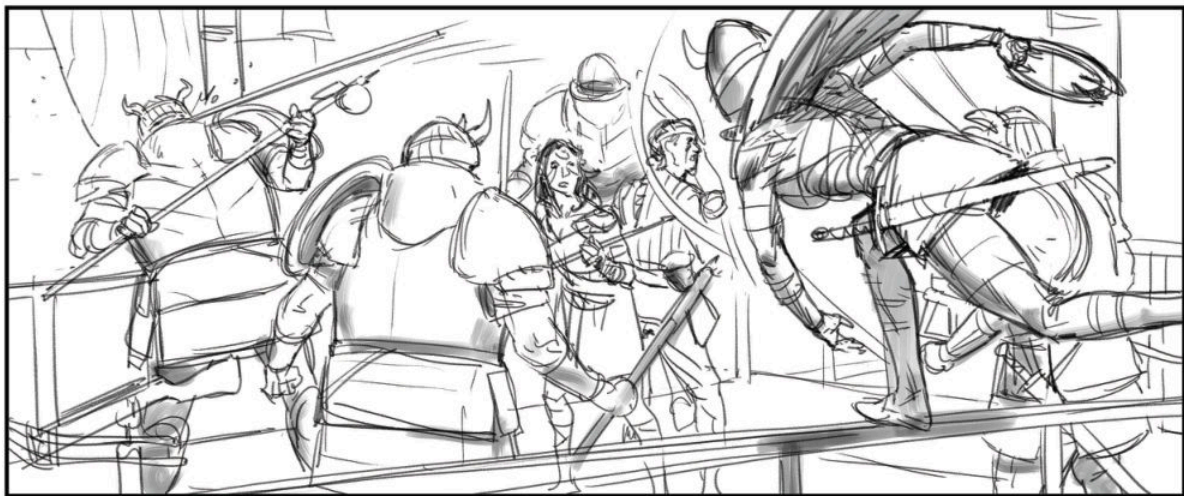


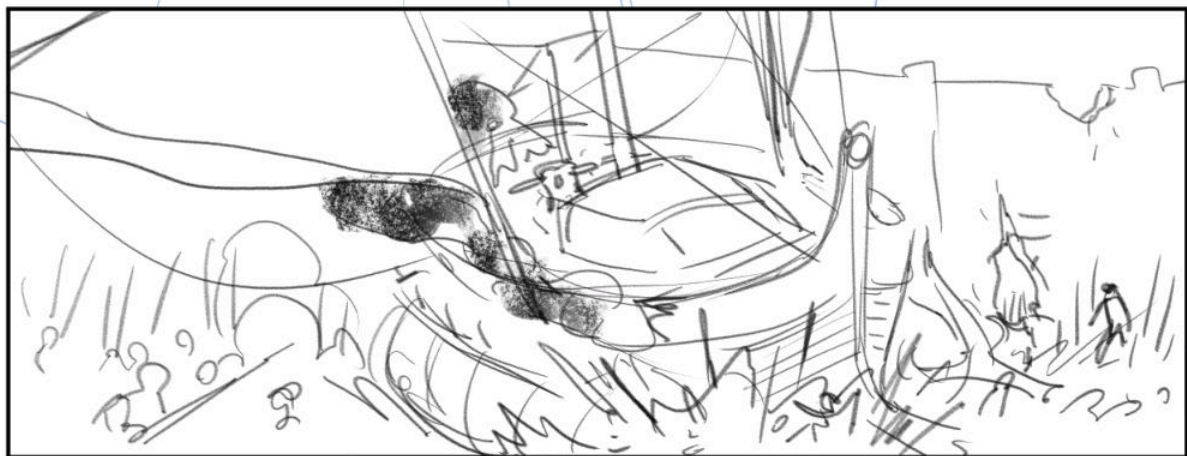
UTU, IT'S ALMOST TIME. YOU KNOW WHAT YOU MUST DO.

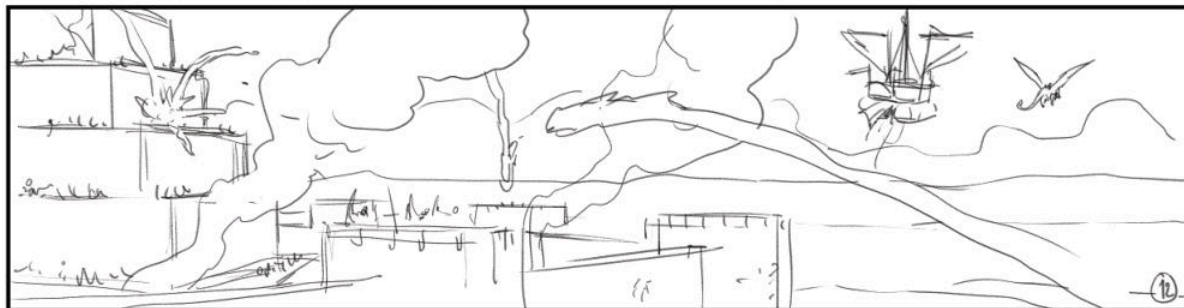
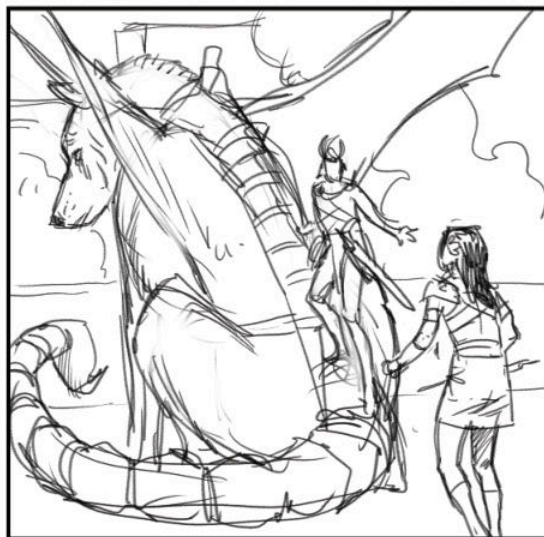


NO, NO! LEAVE ME ALONE!











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